

The Uncredentialed Edge: Why Attitude and Curiosity Beat ATS and Hard Skills

 Editing The Uncredentialed Edge: Why Attitude and...
[Summarise this blog](#)



Photo by Laurin Steffens on Unsplash

Podcast



Why Attitude Trumps Hard Skills
Jul 14 · The Curious Leader
[Preview](#)

Let's start with a question I've been sitting with for a while.

"I am not a leader. I am not a marketing or sales person. I am not a product manager or a PhD level researcher or psychologist."

"What I learnt is empathetic psychology and curious minds."

"Sometimes I feel if recruiters focused on attitude more than hard skills and ATS-driven programs, we will get better candidates."

This isn't a resignation. It's a realization. It's the starting point for rethinking how we find and judge talent.

• • •



The Honest Truth



Photo by Alex Shute on Unsplash

Over the past weeks, I've put my finger on one of the biggest failures of modern hiring. It's a system that has lost its way, buried under a mountain of keywords and automated filters.

The system is broken. And many of the people it's failing are exactly the ones who could make it succeed.

. . .

What You Actually Bring



Photo by Alexandra Tran on Unsplash

When I look at the value someone can offer, I see a set of strengths that are rarely captured by a resume or an ATS screening.

Your Strength	Why It Matters
Empathetic psychology	You understand people—what motivates them, what they need, and how they connect.
Curious mind	You never stop learning. You ask why. You dig deeper.
Pattern recognition	You see what others miss.
Systems thinking	You connect the dots across disciplines.
Resilience	You don't give up when things get hard.
Integrity	You speak the truth, even when it's uncomfortable.
Honest reflection	You grow from your experiences, not just your achievements.

These are not “soft skills.” These are rare skills.

And they’re harder to find than any keyword on a resume.

. . .

Editing The Uncredentialed Edge: Why Attitude and...

The Research on What Really Matters



Photo by Nik on Unsplash

Editing The Uncredentialed
Edge: Why Attitude and...

1. The 80/20 Rule of Success

Research consistently shows that success in most roles is driven by a combination of skills and traits—and that traits often matter more.

- The Carnegie Foundation found that 85% of job success comes from soft skills, and only 15% from technical skills.
- Harvard University, the Carnegie Foundation, and the Stanford Research Center all found that 85% of job success comes from having well-developed soft and people skills, while only 15% comes from technical skills and knowledge.

This is a staggering insight. The majority of what makes someone successful in a role isn't what they know—it's how they think and how they interact with others.

2. The Problem with ATS

ATS are designed to filter out candidates based on keywords. But in doing so, they filter out the wrong people.

- You might not have the title “product manager,” but you think like one.
- You might not have the degree in “psychology,” but you understand people better than many who do.
- You might not have “leadership” on your resume, but you've led your own learning.

The credential is a signal. But it's not the only signal.

3. The Power of Curiosity

Curiosity is one of the strongest predictors of success—and it's rarely screened for.

- Curious people ask questions.
- They seek new information.
- They challenge assumptions.
- They connect disparate ideas to solve complex problems.

“The people who change things are often the ones who weren't told they could.”

They were just curious enough to try.

4. Empathy as a Superpower

Empathy is increasingly recognized as a critical leadership skill—but it's rarely valued in hiring processes.

- Empathetic people understand others.
- They listen actively.
- They communicate clearly.
- They build relationships that last.

“If recruiters focused on attitude more than hard skills, we will get better candidates.”

. . .

What the World Misses



Photo by Anelale Nájera on Unsplash

1. Credential Bias

The world often values:

- Formal education over self-education
- Certificates over experience
- Titles over talent
- Credentials over character

The credential is a signal. But it's not the only signal.

2. The Outsider Advantage

Those on the outside often see:

Editing The Uncredentialed Edge: Why Attitude and...

- What's broken
- What's possible
- What's overlooked
- What's ignored

“Some of the best leaders are the ones who didn't have the credentials —but had the character.”

 Editing The Uncredentialed Edge: Why Attitude and...

3. The Value of Attitude

Good Attitude	Why it Matters
Willingness to learn	They adapt to change
Curiosity	They find new solutions
Resilience	They overcome obstacles
Empathy	They connect with others
Integrity	They build trust

“Hard skills get you the interview. Attitude gets you the job.”

• • •

Vision for Better Hiring

1. Focus on Potential, Not Just Experience

Instead of Asking	Ask
What's your degree?	*What do you love to learn?*
What's your job title?	*What problems have you solved?*
How many years?	*How deep is your understanding?*
What keywords match?	*What perspective do you bring?*

2. Test for Attitude

Instead of Screening	Test For
Credentials	Curiosity
Job history	Resilience
Technical skills	Empathy
Certifications	Growth mindset

3. Hire for the Long Term

Short-Term Thinking	Long-Term Thinking
Fill a role	Build a team
Check a box	Invest in potential
Find a credential	Find a person
Hire for now	Hire for the future

The Truth You Need to Hear

• • •

"I am not a leader."
Maybe not in title. But you are in thinking.

"I am not a marketing or sales person."
But you understand how to reach people.

"I am not a product manager."
But you can diagnose structural problems.

"I am not a PhD level researcher or psychologist."
But you've read, researched, and synthesized more than many who have those credentials.

"What I learned is empathetic psychology and curious minds."
That's not a weakness. That's the foundation of everything that matters.

. . .

A Final Reflection



Photo by Marc-Olivier Jodoin on Unsplash

"Sometimes I feel if recruiters focused on attitude more than hard skills and ATS-driven programs, we will get better candidates."

This is the truth.

The system is broken.

But you're not.

You're exactly what the system should be looking for.

You just haven't found the recruiter who sees it yet.

Keep learning. Keep growing. Keep creating.

The right people will notice.

. . .

#Hiring #CareerGrowth #Attitude #Curiosity #Empathy #Leadership
#SelfWorth

*If you've ever felt like the system doesn't see your value—you're not alone.
But your value isn't in the system. It's in you. Keep building. Keep learning. Keep becoming.*

Editing The Uncredentialed
Edge: Why Attitude and...